

Performing Rigor: Reflexivity in HCI/CSCW

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Reflexivity has become a routine expectation in qualitative HCI, often expressed through positionality statements or defensive methodological claims. Yet these practices risk drifting into procedural forms that foreground researcher identity or procedural compliance rather than the systematic interpretive work through which qualitative insight is produced. We examine how longstanding tensions between interpretive and measurement-oriented approaches to qualitative inquiry are negotiated in contemporary HCI. Drawing on a citation analysis of 919 ACM publications referencing *Reliability and Inter-Rater Reliability in Qualitative Research* (2019), along with close readings of a CHI/CSCW subsample, we analyze how IRR is invoked as a methodological reference point for articulating qualitative rigor. We identify recurring configurations in which interpretive commitments coexist with expectations around coding, agreement, and validation. We argue that these configurations reflect a recurring tension within methodological discourse in how rigor is articulated and evaluated. In response, we propose *generative reflexivity*—a stance that centers interpretive humility, traces how understanding was produced, and foregrounds analytic process, rather than relying on identity disclosure or pseudo-quantitative coding practices.

CCS Concepts: • **Human-centered computing** → **Human computer interaction (HCI)**; **HCI theory, concepts and models**;

Additional Key Words and Phrases: Reflexivity, Positionality, HCI, Methodology, Epistemology

1 Introduction

Qualitative research in HCI has increasingly emphasized interpretive approaches that foreground meaning, context, and the situated nature of knowledge production [7, 8, 22, 24, 55]. Alongside this shift, practices such as reflexivity and the provision of positionality statements have become more visible and, in many venues, expected components of qualitative research reporting.

This coexistence of interpretive commitments and measurement-oriented expectations produces tension in how qualitative rigor is articulated and enacted. Prior work in HCI has critiqued the increasing formalization of reflexivity and positionality, noting that such practices can become standardized, procedural, or disconnected from analytic decision-making [26, 53, 74]. Moreover, these tensions are not limited to reflexive disclosure; they extend into analytic practices such as coding, where similar pressures toward standardization and validation persist. Methodological debates around coding, reliability, and thematic analysis have highlighted ongoing ambiguity in how qualitative researchers navigate competing epistemological frameworks [61].

In this paper, we argue that these dynamics reflect a slow epistemic erosion in qualitative HCI, in which interpretive commitments are articulated at the level of rhetoric, while analytic practices continue to draw on measurement-oriented logics. First, reflexivity has become a routine expectation in qualitative HCI, particularly in research involving vulnerable and marginalized communities. But in adhering to values-driven research—through increasingly standardized positionality statements and ritualized declarations of reflexive practice—the field

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ACM 1557-7325/2026/7-ART

<https://doi.org/10.1145/3831595>

risks neglecting the interpretive labor that underpins qualitative inquiry. Second, researchers often reject formal metrics such as inter-rater reliability (IRR) while retaining underlying assumptions about consistency, validation, and agreement as indicators of analytic quality.

While prior HCI work has critiqued positionality statements and reflexive disclosure (e.g., [53, 74]), this paper shifts focus from reflexivity as representational practice to how methodological artifacts—particularly IRR—structure the evaluation of qualitative rigor in practice. Debates surrounding coding, agreement, validation, and IRR are therefore not merely technical questions but sites where differing understandings of qualitative knowledge are negotiated. Like positionality statements, these practices function as mechanisms through which researchers make interpretive work visible and defend claims to rigor.

To investigate how these tensions manifest in practice, we looked at how IRR is used and discussed within qualitative HCI. IRR occupies a particularly revealing position in methodological debates because it sits at the boundary between interpretive and positivist approaches to qualitative analysis. Unlike other methodological touchstones in HCI—such as thematic analysis or positionality frameworks—which are more uniformly aligned with interpretive traditions, IRR is explicitly contested. It is widely cited across qualitative HCI while simultaneously critiqued as incompatible with interpretive epistemologies [61]. This dual status makes it a particularly effective analytic tracer for examining how researchers negotiate competing commitments to interpretation and measurement in practice.

Drawing on a corpus of CHI and CSCW papers that cite McDonald et al.'s (2019) IRR paper [61], we treat citations as a site of epistemic negotiation, through which arguments and commitments are invoked and sometimes misconstrued. By unpacking the relationship between reflexivity and positionality and by empirically examining how the field invokes reliability [61], we offer a conceptual critique, field evidence, and a constructive path forward for reflexivity in qualitative HCI. Specifically, this paper contributes three main insights:

First, we demonstrate how reliability is invoked within contemporary qualitative HCI, drawing on a citation analysis of CHI and CSCW papers that reference McDonald et al. (2019) [61]. Second, we show how these invocations reveal persistent tensions between interpretive and measurement-oriented logics in qualitative research. Third, we introduce generative reflexivity as an alternative framework that re-centers analytic reasoning and interpretive labor, moving beyond both procedural reflexivity and residual measurement logics.

By *interpretive labor*, we refer to the analytic work through which qualitative researchers generate meaning from data—deciding what to attend to, how to group observations, how to handle ambiguity and disagreement, and how to move from situated accounts to broader conceptual insight. Unlike procedural markers of rigor (e.g., positionality statements or agreement metrics), interpretive labor involves making the reasoning behind analysis visible: how interpretations were constructed, challenged, and refined on their own terms.

2 Reflexivity in Social Science and HCI

Reflexivity is not a recent methodological development, nor has it ever been conceptually stable. Its contemporary uptake in HCI builds on longstanding debates in sociology, anthropology, and feminist methodology concerning the status of knowledge, representation, and researcher subjectivity. Early critiques of ethnographic realism challenged the notion that research could transparently represent social reality, arguing instead that accounts are shaped by the values, positioning, and interpretive frameworks of the researcher [13, 14, 41]. These critiques, often described as a “crisis of representation” [57], gave rise to reflexive approaches that sought to make the researcher’s role visible in the production of knowledge. Within HCI and CSCW, these concerns intersect with ethnomethodological and practice-oriented traditions that treat social order as an ongoing, accountable accomplishment of action [10, 35, 56].

At the same time, reflexivity has been subject to sustained critique. Scholars have cautioned that reflexive practices can become overly confessional or detached from the phenomena under study, shifting attention from

participants to the researcher's biography [56, 58, 75]. Ethnomethodological perspectives sharpen this critique by treating reflexivity not as self-disclosure, but as an ordinary feature of action: the ways in which activities are made observable, reportable, and intelligible in practice [35]. From this view, reflexivity is not secured through declarative statements about the researcher, but through the disciplined production of interpretations—how categories are applied, how observations are rendered meaningful, and how analytic claims are warranted.

Reflexivity has been used to mean at least two different things. In feminist and interpretivist traditions, reflexivity often refers to critical attention to the researcher's position, assumptions, and role in knowledge production [44]. Ethnomethodology, by contrast, provided one of the earliest and most influential accounts of reflexivity [35, 56]. In this tradition, reflexivity refers to the way actions and accounts are mutually constitutive: social activities are produced as intelligible through the very descriptions and practices that make them observable [35]. Reflexivity in this sense is not primarily a matter of self-disclosure but of accountability and practical reasoning. While both traditions reject the possibility of neutral, detached observation, they locate reflexive work in different places, with one emphasizing critical examination of the researcher's position, while the other emphasizing the accountable production of descriptions and interpretations. Distinguishing these traditions is important because contemporary HCI discussions often move between them without acknowledging their different assumptions about what reflexivity is meant to accomplish. In the ethnomethodological tradition, reflexivity concerns the relationship between actions and the accounts through which those actions are rendered intelligible, rather than the researcher's own positionality.

This ambiguity is visible in contemporary HCI's treatment of reflexivity. While reflexivity is frequently operationalized through disclosures about researcher identity, ethnomethodological accounts treated reflexivity as a property of situated action itself. The question was not who the analyst is, but how social realities become recognizable, accountable, and describable in practice.

These debates highlight that reflexivity has never been a settled solution to questions of rigor, but an ongoing site of tension between competing epistemological commitments. Our work builds on this tradition by examining how these tensions—between representation and interpretation, subjectivity and rigor—are reconfigured in qualitative HCI practice, and where reflexivity is increasingly formalized as a methodological expectation while remaining conceptually and epistemologically unsettled.

Reflexivity and positionality have become increasingly visible features of qualitative HCI research, particularly in work engaging feminist, participatory, and justice-oriented traditions [26, 69, 74]. The growing emphasis on reflexivity in HCI draws heavily on feminist qualitative social science [36, 43, 44, 82], where it is often associated with ethical rigor and critical awareness. Bardzell and Bardzell [4] helped to foreground positionality as an explicit methodological concern within HCI, drawing on feminist epistemology to argue that researchers' values, commitments, and standpoints shape both the conduct and interpretation of research. Subsequent work, such as Schlesinger et al. [69], further emphasized the importance of articulating researchers' positionality as a reflexive practice.

Yet, recent work in HCI has critically examined positionality and reflexive practice, identifying tensions around disclosure, representation, and researcher responsibility [25, 26, 54]. While these critiques focus primarily on the promises and limitations of positionality and reflexive disclosure, our concern is different. We examine how methodological artifacts—particularly IRR—structure the conditions under which qualitative rigor is recognized and evaluated in practice.

2.1 The Rise of Positionality in HCI

Within HCI, reflexivity often takes the form of positionality statements—short narrative disclosures meant to surface the researcher's social location and relationship to the research context. These have become especially common in feminist HCI and interview-based studies, where their omission may be viewed as a methodological

shortcoming [74]. Over the last few years, positionality has shifted from a reflective gesture to a near-mandatory component of many qualitative papers [74]. In some subfields, omitting a positionality statement risks triggering a reviewer demand for correction [74]. Singh [74] found that in 2024, 111 CHI papers included positionality papers, up substantially from previous years.

Yet, as Finlay warns, reflexivity carries a “problematic potential” [29]: it can become self-indulgent, overly confessional, or detached from the core analytic work. The standardization of positionality statements can have unintended consequences. Increasingly granular disclosures of researcher identity are often accompanied by ever-more elaborate demographic tables that signal quantification while also fragmenting participant identity into endlessly particularized categories, to the extent that participants may recognize themselves in the data, raising both confidentiality concerns and epistemological burdens.¹

The mere act of naming identity-related complexity—whether of the researcher or the participant—has come to stand in for analytic depth. Reflexive transparency—or the performance of it—becomes a proxy for methodological rigor. Identity becomes both method and outcome, while critique turns inward—preoccupied not with the phenomenon under study, but with mapping the identities through which it is seen.

This trend echoes Dourish’s [22] critique of “implications for design” as a prescribed gesture of HCI legitimacy: a once-meaningful practice becomes formalized, then overextended. Reflexivity, similarly, may shift focus away from the subject of inquiry and toward the researcher’s own ideological stance. The result is a form of epistemic myopia: a loss of analytic synthesis, the hyper-fragmentation of findings, and a self-referential loop in which the researcher’s biography overshadows the inquiry. It also runs the risk of forcing authors to share identity characteristics such as sexual orientation, race, and other aspects of their background that they may not wish to share or may not consider relevant to the analysis.²

While much of the contemporary discussion has focused on reflexivity and positionality, our analysis turns to qualitative coding and IRR as a particularly visible site where broader tensions around rigor, interpretation, and methodological accountability are negotiated in practice.

3 Phenomenology and Third Wave HCI: Humility, Not Opacity

Before advancing our core argument, we situate it within third-wave HCI, which draws on phenomenology to resist the positivist impulse of first-wave HCI and the cognitive, behavioral orientation of second-wave HCI—both premised on the idea that humans are predictable, their actions model-able and calculable [11]. Third-wave HCI instead foregrounds contingency, multifaceted experience, and situatedness, recognizing that experience is shaped by identity, culture, and context [11, 39, 45]. Phenomenology contributes less a method than a stance of epistemic humility: an effort to understand experience on its own terms while recognizing the limits of one’s access to another’s perspective.

Third-wave HCI adopts phenomenology not as a rigid philosophy but as an interpretive stance informing experience-centered and reflective design [73, 83]. It often builds on Merleau-Ponty, who emphasized the embodied basis of experience, and Schutz, who extended phenomenology into the social realm by examining how meaning is constructed in everyday interaction [62, 70]. Dourish [21], in turn, situates embodiment at the center of HCI, framing interaction with computing artifacts as meaning-making through situated practice, drawing also on Heidegger’s analysis of being-in-the-world [46] and Wittgenstein’s accounts of language and practice. The discourse of embodiment broadly [23] casts interaction with computing artifacts as meaning-making through

¹To be clear, intersectional reflexivity remains a vital corrective to the universalizing tendencies of earlier research paradigms. Scholars such as Costanza-Chock have made a compelling case for the importance of centering marginalized identities in participatory and justice-oriented research [17]. Our concern is not with the principle of reflexivity, but with its procedural overuse and symbolic inflation.

²We have heard this in reflexivity and other adjacent workshops where inevitably someone has a story about being “outed” by a positionality statement.

situated practice, drawing also on Heidegger's analysis of being-in-the-world [46] and Wittgenstein's accounts of language and practice [81].

HCI's phenomenological tradition engages with lived experience, privileging how people make sense of their worlds. At its core, and reductively, it involves "bracketing" one's assumptions [48]³—attending deliberately to how others experience and interpret their realities rather than filtering them through preexisting theoretical or personal lenses. This orientation decouples the researcher from the interpretive foreground, centering participants' meaning-making.

Phenomenology thus informs interaction criticism, design interpretation, and experience-centered design. Bardzell highlights its value in revealing the affective, embodied, and situated dimensions of user experience, particularly through close readings of participants' lifeworlds [2]. Drawing on feminist phenomenology, including Simone de Beauvoir, this perspective examines not only perception and embodiment but also how they are shaped by power, gender, and social positioning [1, 3, 20]. De Beauvoir reframes phenomenology as a method for analyzing how subjectivity is constituted through lived experience in relation to systemic conditions—what it means to be embodied as the Other. She complicates bracketing by showing that, while researchers may strive to decenter themselves, their interpretive frameworks are always shaped by structural and historical forces [20].

Phenomenology is intentionally underspecified [49], but good practice demands examining experience and questioning our assumptions about what surrounds us. Its rigor lies in bridging the subjective and the structural. As Nagel reminds us, it is "hard to know what it is like to be a bat" [65]—yet phenomenology offers tools to approach that unknowability with care.

Speculative works like Flusser and Bec's *Vampyroteuthis Infernalis* [31] extend this humility through a fictional ethnography of the vampire squid. Blending marine biology, media theory, parody, and allegory, they invite readers to inhabit an alien sensorium—not to master it, but to reframe the limits of human-centered perception. This posthuman phenomenology aligns with HCI's interest in designing for perspectives that resist easy translation [72].

In HCI, phenomenology is less a decision-making algorithm than a sensibility—one that risks dead ends if treated as method alone, but remains invaluable as a sociological and interpretive practice. It calls for dwelling in ambiguity, resisting premature closure, and avoiding attempts to "correct" participants' worldviews. The point is not that perceptions are empirically "true," but that they carry real-world consequences. For example, avoiding a hospital due to perceived surveillance has material effects, whether or not the surveillance is empirically confirmed. This consequence-oriented framing underpins studies of structurally marginalized populations—from criminal justice avoidance [38] to distrust of institutions [67] to digital exclusion [27]—and aligns with de Beauvoir's view that subjectivity is always situated within, and shaped by, structural conditions [20].

In this sense, phenomenology in third-wave HCI embodies epistemic humility [80]: recognizing that researchers cannot fully occupy another's perspective, yet can work to understand it on its own terms. This contrasts with reflexive practices that over-personalize meaning through the researcher's identity matrix. In some HCI work, reflexivity becomes a performative obligation—a badge of relevance or proximity to participants, where position is treated as an epistemic credential rather than a contextual factor. Well-intentioned as such performance may be, it can double down on identity multiplicity—by both researchers and participants—and risk reproducing the determinism it seeks to resist [28]: the idea that identity categories dictate what one can perceive, experience, or claim to know.

In what follows, we examine how these longstanding tensions reappear in contemporary HCI practice as three recurring patterns. The concerns we outline emerge from three sources. First, they build on longstanding

³Husserl's concept of epoché or "bracketing"—the suspension of prior assumptions to attend to lived experience—has been extensively critiqued, particularly within hermeneutic phenomenology. Thinkers such as Martin Heidegger argue that interpretation is always shaped by one's historical, cultural, and experiential situatedness, making complete bracketing impossible [46].

critiques of reflexivity in sociology, anthropology, and HCI, including concerns about confessional reflexivity, proceduralization, and the displacement of analytic inquiry [29, 54, 56]. Second, they reflect recurring tensions we observed in our analysis of citation practices surrounding IRR, where interpretive commitments often coexisted with measurement-oriented indicators of rigor. Finally, they draw on broader methodological debates within HCI concerning positionality, representation, and the evaluation of qualitative research. We present these not as exhaustive categories, but as recurring patterns through which reflexivity is currently articulated and enacted in the field.

4 Problem Areas in Contemporary Reflexivity

Reflexivity denotes an ongoing epistemic stance, while positionality refers to a researcher's declared identity in relation to the research. Increasingly, the two are conflated, turning practices meant to surface power and enhance accountability into routine gestures that often replace deeper analytic engagement. We identify three patterns related to this: reflexivity as methodological ritual, reflexive introspection mistaken for rigor, and inclusion without theoretical grounding.

These patterns are not only conceptual critiques but are also observable in how qualitative methods are articulated in practice. In the next section, we examine how these tensions surface empirically through citation practices surrounding IRR, a methodological site where competing logics of rigor become particularly visible.

4.1 Reflexivity as Methodological Ritual

Reflexivity in HCI has increasingly normalized into a “knee-jerk checklist”: routine identity disclosures—race, gender, positional relation to participants—offered in a paragraph or footnote and left unanalyzed. These gestures are often treated as sufficient markers of ethical engagement or analytic transparency, regardless of whether they shape the research process or interpretation.

What once disrupted assumptions of neutrality now risks procedural compliance: box-ticking to satisfy reviewers [74], sometimes undermining researcher credibility [68]. Naming identity can create the illusion that acknowledging it mitigates its influence or that identity is a fixed source of interpretation, displacing harder questions about how knowledge is produced, for whom, and to what end.

As Lynch warns, reflexivity can become a badge of virtue rather than a tool for analysis [56]. Reflexivity should animate the research process—not decorate its margins. This echoes calls in feminist HCI to embed values, ethics, and accountability into methods and theory, not just disclosures [4, 69].

4.2 Confession is Not Method: Reflexivity's Analytic Undoing

Reflexive disclosure is too often mistaken for rigor or authority. Increasingly, there is a sense that examinations of researcher identity stand in for analysis, treating positionality not as context but as a credential. Reflexivity becomes a biographical aside—an introspective moment mistaken for analytic substance.

We outline three interrelated risks: the replacement of arbitrary hegemonic authority with assumption that marginalization confers equal peremptory authority, projecting reflexive meaning onto ordinary participant behavior, and mistaking confession for rigor. Each reveals how reflexivity, when untethered from analysis, can obscure more than it reveals.

Three risks follow. First, marginalization is assumed to confer epistemic authority, ignoring that privilege—educational or institutional—can shape perspective as much as identity [52]. Sharing identity with participants may build rapport but does not guarantee understanding, and overidentification can flatten difference or obscure power asymmetries—leading participants to believe themselves more understood than they are, or prompting researchers to overidentify in ways that flatten difference or become patronizing.

Second, reflexivity can become so overextended that even mundane participant behaviors are absorbed into speculative narratives of power and positionality. Folkes [33], for example, describes interpreting participants cleaning their homes before her arrival as recognition of her class privilege as “an educated researcher from a prestigious institution,” though such actions could just as easily reflect everyday hospitality norms. In such cases, researchers risk overwriting participants’ own sense-making with self-centered interpretations, extending those projections far beyond the encounter itself. When researchers assign reflexive meaning to ambiguous or ordinary behavior, they risk missing participants’ own framings.

Third, biography is often treated as proof of trustworthiness. Reflexive disclosure can help situate a researcher and make visible some of the conditions under which knowledge is produced, but it does not itself establish the quality of an analysis [30, 66]. Qualitative rigor rests on the interpretive work through which observations are transformed into meaningful accounts, not on autobiographical disclosure alone. When rigor is sought primarily through biographical credentials or procedural demonstrations of methodological care, the analytic reasoning that underpins qualitative insight can recede from view [8, 9]. Qualitative findings are ultimately judged by the coherence, explanatory power, and theoretical contribution of the interpretations they generate, rather than by who the researcher is or how extensively they narrate their own position [32, 37, 77]. As Finlay reminds us, good qualitative researchers are storytellers, not tally-keepers [30]. Storytelling requires careful interpretation, not autobiographical credentials.

Phenomenology reminds us to dwell with participants’ realities, bracketing identity to avoid substituting our explanatory frames for theirs. Reflexivity, done well, recognizes distance, not proximity. This need for humility extends to HCI itself. As a field, we often expect participants to exhibit vigilance and literacy in navigating complex sociotechnical systems—being more cautious, critical, or privacy-protective—while we remain deeply entangled in the very infrastructures we critique. We problematize surveillance, personalization, and datafication, yet rely on these same tools in our research and daily work. This asymmetry exposes a disciplinary blind spot: without turning the reflexive lens inward, we risk holding participants to standards we do not meet ourselves, foreclosing more honest, symmetrical accounts of technological entanglement.

4.3 Inclusion is not Epistemic Closure

To be clear, insights from different identities, other cultural or national contexts can meaningfully inform U.S.-based research [50]. But that does not mean it is analytically appropriate to import participants into a study frame that was not designed to account for their specific sociolegal context. Doing so risks misinterpretation and weakens the explanatory power of the research.

4.3.1 Intersectionality Misapplied. The impulse to widen samples or oversample the most vulnerable is often ethically motivated but analytically thin. Simply adding identities or selecting participants based on perceived marginalization does not clarify a phenomenon. Intersectionality, as originally theorized, examines how overlapping systems of power shape experience—not as an additive checklist [19]. Patricia Hill Collins reminds us that intersectionality is contextual: power, law, and culture determine where and how oppression manifests [15]. Overinclusive sampling without contextual grounding can even reinforce the structural asymmetries it seeks to critique [5]. Similarly, Bilge warns that academic intersectionality often becomes branding—signaling politics without structural analysis [6].

4.3.2 Algorithmic Determinism and Overfitting the Margins. This context-free version of intersectionality mirrors the logics of algorithmic systems critiqued in HCI, where identity is treated as a static input variable—a proxy for behavior or belief—rather than a socially, culturally, and historically constructed position [42].

At the same time, intersectionality’s uptake in HCI has sometimes hardened into an identity-based determinism of a different sort. By focusing narrowly on ever-finer categories of experience, we risk reproducing the logic of

algorithmic profiling: a world where outcomes are presumed to follow inevitably from inputs. This hyper-specified epistemology flattens complexity into predictability, leaving little space for interpretation, uncertainty, or shared meaning-making.

What gets lost is interpretive synthesis and with it, the possibility of hypothesis-building—framing provisional claims, tracing patterns, and generating theoretical insights that resonate beyond the individual case. Qualitative work often scaffolds later quantitative inquiry, guiding what is measured, how constructs are operationalized, and which relationships are tested.

Such inquiry requires imagination, values, and a willingness to be wrong. Defaulting to identity as explanation trades this interpretive stance for the logic of the black-box algorithm: unaccountable, overconfident, and uninterpretable. As HCI increasingly integrates computational methods, it is critical to distinguish between interpretable models, such as logistic regression, which test falsifiable hypotheses, and machine-learned predictions that obscure reasoning. While our critique of algorithmic logic is partly metaphorical—calling attention to how identity can be treated as a predictive input in both AI systems and reflexive practices—it also signals a concrete methodological concern. As HCI increasingly embraces mixed and computational methods, it is essential to preserve the interpretive scaffolding of hypothesis-building, pattern recognition, and theoretical synthesis. Logistic regression, for instance, allows for falsifiable and interpretable models; this is quite different from relying on opaque machine-learned predictions as epistemic authority.

In parallel, sampling practices are often driven by unexamined assumption that more minoritized = more meaningful. This risks performative inclusion, where participant selection signals ethical awareness but remains analytically untethered. The deeper question is whether we are studying a phenomenon or performing our commitments. Presuming static vulnerability without contextual grounding risks overlooking harms that operate through normativity. For example, research on digital privacy threats to reproductive health shows that individuals following “ordinary” usage patterns may be equally vulnerable to harm, precisely because they are not perceived as exceptional or at risk [27, 60].

This logic also deprioritizes generalizability—when in fact, understanding norms and shared experiences is essential not to universalize, but to contrast, contextualize, and explain divergence [32]. Some of the most meaningful social critique begins with what is widespread or taken for granted [76]—enabling us to attend to what is uncommon and why [59].

4.3.3 Participant Tables. In some cases, claims to situated or particular insight are supported through the presentation of demographic detail—such as tables indicating participants’ identities or counts of representation—without clearly articulating how these characteristics shaped the interpretation itself.

Participant tables, especially those listing highly specific identity attributes, can inadvertently “out” participants or burden them with representing entire identity categories. While often meant as gestures of inclusion, they invite reviewers to demand identity-based analyses even when the study design does not support them. Researchers frequently disclaim generalizability in response, but qualitative richness need not be generalizable to be meaningful [32]. Diversity should inform study design, not serve as a decorative flourish or shield against critique. In an era of preregistration and planned comparisons in quantitative work, overly granular demographic slicing pulls qualitative work in the opposite direction.

4.3.4 Generalizability and Pattern Recognition. Meaningful critique often starts with what is common, not what is exceptional—failing to recognize this can obscure risk and hinder theory-building. The overemphasis on researcher identity can also inhibit pattern recognition or theoretical synthesis. When we do interviews, for instance, we should not want our participants to feel like we already know what they are going to say, but rather understand them when they do. It encourages reading each case as utterly unique—obscuring shared narratives or middle-range [63] theoretical insights. A better approach might ask: What tensions exist between this participant’s view and broader social narratives?

These patterns that we have surfaced signal not the failure of reflexivity, but its departure from substantive inquiry. In the next section, we outline an approach that reclaims reflexivity as interpretive labor—less a declaration of who we are, and more a demonstration of how we come to know.

5 IRR as Lens on Qualitative Rigor

The previous section identified a broader epistemic tension in qualitative HCI: researchers frequently invoke interpretive commitments while simultaneously drawing on procedural markers of rigor that originates in measurement-focused traditions. To examine how these tensions are enacted in practice, we turn to debates surrounding IRR. IRR occupies a particularly generative position in methodological debates. It is widely recognized as a hallmark of positivist approaches to qualitative analysis, yet it is also frequently discussed, adapted, or explicitly rejected within interpretive traditions [61]. This makes IRR a useful lens for examining how researchers articulate and justify claims about rigor in the presence of competing epistemological commitments.

We focus on how IRR is invoked not as a technical procedure, but as a methodological reference point through which authors position their epistemological stance. While this paper is centrally concerned with reflexivity, we examine debates around IRR as a particularly visible site where broader tensions around interpretive practice and methodological rigor become observable in HCI. We focus specifically on a citation community organized around McDonald et al.'s (2019) IRR paper [61], treating citations not as indicators of correctness but as sites of epistemic negotiation. In this sense, the corpus is intentionally constructed around a site of contestation—the necessity of IRR—allowing us to observe how interpretive and measurement-oriented logics are articulated, reconciled, or left unresolved in practice.

This dynamic is not unique to qualitative research. Across methodological traditions, analytic practice depends on shared references—metrics, datasets, model outputs, or coding schemes. Whether invoking IRR or statistical tests, what counts as sufficient rigor is therefore not given by technique alone, but emerges through the stabilization of codes and data in practice.

We asked: How is rigor negotiated within a citation community organized around IRR? We recognize that analyzing the uptake of one of the authors' own prior work introduces a reflexive tension. Our goal is not to evaluate correctness of citation, but to examine how a widely circulated methodological reference functions within the field as a site of epistemic negotiation. The IRR paper is particularly useful as an analytic entry point because it sits at a point of methodological contention: it is widely cited across qualitative HCI, yet explicitly challenges the use of reliability metrics. This makes it a productive object for examining how researchers reconcile interpretive commitments with inherited norms of measurement.

Across the corpus, we observe a recurring pattern in which authors explicitly reject IRR while simultaneously invoking related assumptions about consistency, validation, or agreement. We interpret this not simply as inconsistency, but as a form of methodological positioning. In these cases, rejecting IRR functions less as a substantive departure from measurement-oriented logics and more as a way of signaling alignment with interpretive traditions, even as elements of those logics persist in practice.

We describe this as a performative rejection of IRR: a rhetorical move through which authors distance themselves from positivist evaluation metrics while retaining, reconfiguring, or selectively adopting their underlying assumptions. In these accounts, IRR is neither fully embraced nor fully rejected. Rather, it functions as a symbolic boundary marker through which researchers signal interpretivist commitments while continuing to draw on measurement-oriented notions of validation, agreement, and rigor.

5.1 Methods

To assemble our corpus, we first identified all papers in the ACM Digital Library that cite McDonald et al.'s IRR paper [61]. This yielded 919 publications.⁴ For each of these, we coded basic bibliographic information (venue, venue type, and year of publication). Of the 919 papers, 374 (41%) appeared in CHI (30%) or CSCW (11%), which we treat as key sites for qualitative HCI and CSCW methodology.

We selected this corpus to examine how widely circulated methodological reference is mobilized within the field. The IRR paper serves as an analytic lens for tracing how researchers articulate and negotiate epistemological commitments in practice.

We examine how IRR is invoked as a shared reference point across the field and the site of negotiation between multiple epistemologies. Indeed, while it is often treated as a stable methodological anchor, our analysis shows that these citations instead reflect ongoing epistemic negotiation, reinterpretation, and, at times, misalignment.

From these 374 CHI and CSCW papers, we drew a random sample of 40 for close interpretive readings of full methods and findings sections. The sample size was selected to enable in-depth qualitative analysis of how epistemological commitments are articulated in practice, rather than to support statistical inference. Our goal is analytic depth: to trace recurring patterns, tensions, and interpretive moves within complete methodological narratives.

This approach is consistent with prior work that treats citation practices as sites of epistemic analysis rather than objects of measurement [51]. While larger samples may support frequency-based claims, they limit the level of interpretive engagement required to examine how methodological language, analytic procedures, and epistemological positioning cohere—or fail to cohere—within individual studies.

For each sampled paper, we coded:

- **How the IRR paper was cited**, including the explicit rationale (e.g., to justify not computing IRR, to frame coding as interpretive, to motivate a codebook, or simply as a generic reference to “best practices” in qualitative analysis);
- **Data type**, focusing on the presence of qualitative material (e.g., interviews, focus groups, field notes, open-ended survey responses);
- **Analytic approach**, as described by the authors (e.g., reflexive thematic analysis, grounded theory, qualitative content analysis, hybrid or “mixed” thematic approaches);
- **Interpretive-reflexive moves**, such as memo writing, researcher dialogue, “thinking with theory,” reflexive thematic analysis, or explicit claims about contextual and situated interpretation;
- **Positivist markers**, such as formal codebooks, code counts and prevalence claims, IRR statistics (e.g., Cohen’s κ , Krippendorff’s α), language of “validity” and “reliability” as measurement, and appeals to demographic representativeness;⁵
- **The presence of a positionality statement**, and how (if at all) it was connected to the analytic process.

Our goal is not statistical inference but field diagnosis. Rather than treating these patterns as categories of correctness or error, we interpret them as recurring configurations through which researchers position their work in relation to competing logics of rigor.

The first author conducted the interpretive coding and memoing, consistent with reflexive qualitative analysis in which coding is a situated, sense-making activity rather than an exercise in producing interchangeable codes [8, 61]. The co-authors engaged in iterative discussions of patterns, interrogating assumptions, and refining the conceptual distinctions that structure the analysis.

⁴Google Scholar reports over 1,500 citations, suggesting that the ACM Digital Library index excludes some venues and disciplines.

⁵Positivism refers to an approach to knowing through systematic, observable data. It evaluates rigor through concepts such as validity and reliability, which assess the extent to which findings are accurate, consistent, and predictive [40].

In keeping with an interpretivist reading of the corpus, we intentionally avoid quantifying how many papers exemplified each pattern. Numerical reporting would contradict the argument at stake—treating these patterns as measurable “variables” rather than narrative strategies through which authors position their work epistemologically. Our aim is not to assess prevalence but to surface conceptual departure hybridization, and slippages that emerge as the IRR paper circulates across methodological genres.

5.2 Findings

Across the 40 sampled CHI and CSCW papers, several dominant citation patterns emerged in how authors mobilized McDonald et al.’s IRR paper [61] and framed qualitative rigor. These patterns were not merely conceptual stances, but were repeatedly enacted in specific analytic moves—for example, appeals to “complete agreement,” use of consensus coding procedures, explicit calculation of IRR statistics, or references to codebooks as validation tools. Below, we describe the four primary patterns observed.

Pattern 1: Appropriate epistemological alignment. Papers in this category cite the IRR paper to justify *not* pursuing formal agreement metrics on epistemological grounds. Authors explicitly state, for example, that “even if coders agreed, they may interpret the meaning differently,” or that reflexive or grounded theory approaches “do not call for inter-coder reliability.” Correspondingly, these papers foreground interpretive practices such as memoing, iterative discussion, reflexive thematic analysis, negotiated interpretation, or deep contextual reading of transcripts. In these papers, coding is described as a meaning-making tool rather than a measurement procedure. The tone of the methods sections often emphasizes analytic judgment and situated interpretation (“themes were refined through dialogue,” “we prioritized thematic validity over reliability”). Positivist markers—such as formal codebooks, code counts, or prevalence tables—are absent. These papers represent the clearest and most consistent alignment with the epistemic commitments argued in the IRR paper.

In these cases, IRR is not simply omitted but actively re-situated within an interpretive epistemology. This pattern represents the clearest alignment between methodological framing and analytic practice, where commitments to situated meaning-making are consistently reflected in both rhetoric and procedure.

Pattern 2: IRR mechanically invoked or epistemologically in tension. In this pattern, authors cite the IRR paper but nonetheless compute formal reliability statistics—such as Cohen’s κ , Krippendorff’s α , or percentage agreement—often in the same paragraph where they gesture toward interpretive aims. Many papers explicitly describe “validating the codebook,” “checking consistency,” or “establishing coder agreement” before applying the scheme to the full dataset. Some even position IRR as a way to demonstrate the “effectiveness” of a coding scheme or to “ensure consistency across raters,” despite citing the IRR paper.

These papers often display hybridized methods: open or inductive coding is paired with codebooks, reconciliation processes, and formal metrics. The IRR citation appears largely procedural—evidence of awareness of qualitative debates—while positivist norms of reliability remain intact. IRR is invoked alongside continued reliance on measurement practices, suggesting at sort of catch-all epistemological commitment. While authors gesture toward interpretive approaches, the underlying analysis is beholden to notions of consistency, validation, and agreement-type indicators of rigor.

The challenge is not merely whether researchers compute IRR, but how they understand the epistemic commitments of qualitative work. Generative reflexivity directly addresses this: it articulates a coherent interpretive logic that avoids both shallow positivist assurances and reflexivity-as-biography. We intentionally avoid quantifying the prevalence of patterns (e.g., “10 of 40 papers”), because doing so would reproduce the positivist logics we critique. Our aim is not to measure frequency but to characterize how methodological narratives appear and what they reveal about epistemic commitments.

Pattern 3: IRR as rhetorical shield. Papers in this category explicitly cite the IRR paper to justify not reporting IRR, yet retain fundamentally quantitative or measurement-oriented analytic practices. These include:

- detailed, validated codebooks with extensive hierarchical coding structures
- reporting percentages or frequencies of codes or themes
- describing theme saturation or representativeness
- framing themes as “prevalent” or “dominant” in the dataset
- asserting that coding was “inductive” while still applying codes as fixed categories

These papers often use language such as “we did not quantify reliability outside the research team,” “agreement was sufficient,” or “we followed best practices for qualitative analysis,” while continuing to rely on code structure, prevalence, or saturation as evidentiary warrants. In these cases, the IRR citation serves less as an epistemic stance and more as a rhetorical device that allows authors to reject IRR while continuing to operate within a measurement paradigm. Quantification disappears only at the point of IRR; the rest of the analytic logic remains positivist.

This pattern serves to illustrate the way in which IRR can function rhetorically, allowing authors to reject formal reliability while preserving other forms of quantification.

Pattern 4: IRR rejected for consensus as justification. Finally, we identified a set of papers that correctly recognized that formal reliability metrics were unnecessary, yet justified the omission through appeals to consensus rather than epistemology. These authors typically wrote that IRR was not computed because coders “reached complete agreement,” “resolved all disagreements,” or “achieved consensus,” sometimes emphasizing that themes were “mutually validated.”

This framing treats agreement itself—not epistemology—as the reason IRR is unnecessary. Rather than articulating the interpretive logic (coders are not interchangeable, meaning is situated, disagreement is generative), these papers rely on the positivist assumption that agreement is a proxy for rigor. In some cases, consensus is described as producing a “validated” codebook or as evidence that coding was objective. The interpretive process of managing disagreement is flattened, and consensus becomes a substitute for reliability rather than an opportunity for reflexive meaning-making.

These patterns show that the IRR paper now circulates as a methodological touchstone across CHI and CSCW, but in uneven ways. Some authors engage deeply with its epistemological critique, while others cite it formulaically, defensively, or in tension with their own analytic practices. Across the corpus, the citation becomes a site where contemporary HCI negotiates the boundary between interpretivist and positivist norms of rigor—sometimes with clarity, sometimes with slippage, and often with unresolved hybridity.

IRR and positionality statements operate as complementary responses to the problem of demonstrating rigor under conditions of epistemic plurality. Where IRR provides a shared evaluative reference across methodological traditions, positionality statements foreground the situated conditions under which interpretation occurs. Both function as mechanisms for rendering qualitative analysis accountable, yet are not well integrated with the analytic work itself. Instead, they operate as secondary representations of interpretive labor—IRR translating that labor into signals of reliability recognizable across paradigms, and positionality statements framing it in terms of reflexive awareness and ethical responsibility. In practice, both can become decoupled from the interpretive process they are meant to support, operating as performative markers of rigor rather than substantive demonstrations of analytic reasoning. In other words, they black-box analytic rigor, obscuring the interpretive work through which claims are produced.

6 Discussion and Broader Impacts

Our analysis reveals that reflexivity in HCI currently operates within a field-wide tension: researchers articulate interpretive aims, yet reviewing norms, pedagogical practices, and inherited habits of “good qualitative method” continue to demand markers associated with positivist reliability. Ritualized positionality statements, pseudo-quantitative coding, and mechanical references to the IRR paper reflect a broader methodological discourse in

which interpretive rigor is asserted rhetorically but difficult to practice structurally. The implications extend beyond isolated methods sections—they shape how students are trained, how research is evaluated, and how knowledge is legitimized across HCI and CSCW.

Rather than introducing a new critique of reflexivity, our aim is to trace how longstanding tensions—between representation and interpretation, subjectivity and rigor—are currently being negotiated within HCI.

IRR citation practice patterns illustrate this misalignment between stated epistemological commitments and enacted analytic procedures, motivating the need for an alternative framework that more coherently aligns interpretation, method, and claims of rigor.

More broadly, these findings suggest that contemporary HCI has narrowed reflexivity to a particular set of practices around disclosure. As discussed earlier, however, reflexivity has never had a singular meaning. Ethnomethodological traditions, for example, emphasized accountability, practical reasoning, and the ways social realities become recognizable through action and description. From this perspective, the central reflexive question is not who the researcher is, but how interpretations are generated, justified, and rendered accountable. The patterns we observed suggest that this latter concern is often displaced by procedural demonstrations of rigor, including positionality statements, coding protocols, and symbolic engagement with reliability discourse.

6.1 Implications for Reviewing Culture

Reviewer expectations play a central role in the procedural evolution we observe. Across CHI and CSCW—two of the most influential venues for qualitative HCI—reviews often articulate implicit criteria for rigor that are incompatible with interpretive epistemologies. Authors face pressure to report “how many participants said X,” to provide codebooks “for transparency,” or to demonstrate consensus “for validity,” even when these gestures conflict with their analytic stance.

The result is a misalignment between epistemic commitments and performative compliance: authors cite the IRR paper to signal interpretive legitimacy while simultaneously providing code counts or agreement checks to pre-empt reviewer critique. Reviewers often interpret these hybrid practices as evidence that positivist conventions remain the gold standard from which deviations must be justified.

Generative reflexivity suggests a different reviewing orientation—one that treats interpretive transparency, conceptual richness, and coherence between epistemology and method as primary signals of rigor. Instead of asking whether “all coders used the same codes,” reviewers might ask:

- How did the analysis make meaning?
- What interpretive decisions structured insight?
- How did the research team navigate ambiguity or disagreement?
- Does the analytic narrative align with the epistemological stance the authors claim?

This reframing does not loosen standards; it shifts rigor from compliance to clarity, from procedure to argumentation, and from metrics to meaning-making.

6.2 Implications for Graduate Methods Education

The hybridization found in our corpus points to an educational gap. Many HCI researchers learn qualitative methods through lab traditions or peer imitation rather than through sustained methodological or epistemological training. Students often encounter a contradictory message: qualitative research is interpretive, but you still need reliability; reflexivity matters, but mostly as autobiography; coding is subjective, but you should quantify it to show rigor. Generative reflexivity offers an alternative pedagogical pathway.

7 Toward Generative Reflexivity

The patterns observed in IRR citation practices point to a recurring misalignment between epistemological commitments and analytic practice. In response, we propose *generative reflexivity* as a framework for realigning interpretive reasoning, methodological choices, and claims of rigor.

Reflexivity should not be discarded, but it must be reoriented and better understood. As our analysis shows, reflexive practices themselves are not immune to the need for reflexivity: the field's well-intentioned emphasis on ethical accountability has produced new rituals—standardized positionality statements, demographic tables, and performative rejections of IRR—that can obscure rather than illuminate analytic practice. This shift is understandable. Under contemporary reviewing pressures, authors are incentivized to signal rigor through visible and easily auditable markers, even when those markers are only loosely connected to interpretive epistemologies. Yet, just as interaction extends beyond the interface to the social and institutional scales that shape it [4, 71], reflexivity must also operate at multiple levels within individual studies and across the practices that structure the discipline.

Reasserting the generativity of reflexivity therefore requires attention to both sites and scales—recognizing that the commitments enabling rigorous, situated qualitative work also shape the epistemic health of HCI as a field.

We are against treating reflexivity, on the one hand, as a performance of identity—a compulsory section in academic papers, a participant table that checks all the boxes, or a frame of inquiry focused on marginality as inherently revelatory, without consideration of the complex contextual dynamics at play. On the other, we take issue with claims of reflexivity that are not thoroughly tied to reflexive practice. Instead, we call for a generative reflexivity: one that centers epistemic humility, supports analytic rigor or dialogue, and fosters shared understanding. We use the term “generative” deliberately: not to signal productivity for its own sake, but to emphasize reflexivity's capacity to support interpretation, build theory, and surface meaning that travels beyond the self.

Generative reflexivity shifts the question from “How does my identity legitimate this research?” or “How can I avoid IRR?” to “How did my interpretations emerge, shift, and get challenged during analysis?” It emphasizes methodological transparency over biographical disclosure, epistemic humility over positional authority, and interpretive reasoning over both identity performance and code tallies. The goal is to show how knowledge was constructed—not to credential the researcher nor to turn qualitative codes into proxy measurements.

Crucially, reflexivity should clarify its role in the research process—how it shaped study design, informed data interpretation, or generated insight during analysis—rather than appearing as a detached biographical insert. Reflexivity is not a personal statement about who the researcher is, nor a justification for exempting qualitative work from rigor. Declaring positionality without connecting it to analytic decisions performs identity rather than interpretation. Likewise, rejecting IRR while still treating codes as if they were quantitative units (e.g., reporting frequencies, prevalence claims, or participant tallies) performs interpretivism without practicing it. Both moves signal reflexivity but do not enact it.

The challenge, then, is not whether reflexivity is included, but whether it is doing epistemic work: surfacing contradictions, revealing how interpretations shifted, making visible the decisions that shaped meaning. Inclusion should be driven by analytic and ethical fit—not by demographic checklists or quantification disguised as interpretation. Reflexivity must defend its legitimacy as a mode of knowledge-making, not function as a shield against methodological critique.

7.0.1 What does this look like in practice? Seen this way, reflexivity becomes less about who the researcher is and more about how inquiry unfolds. Generative reflexivity reorients attention from identity to interpretation, from disclosure to explanation, and from counting to meaning-making.

- Make the work of interpretive divergence visible. Rather than describing coding as a march toward uniformity, illuminate how differing readings, questions, hesitations, and interpretive tensions among researchers shaped analytic insight. Show how divergent interpretations opened conceptual possibilities rather than framing them as problems to be “resolved.”
- Inclusion of participant details is driven by analytic and ethical fit. Demographic tables are optional; avoid exhaustive disclosure if it is irrelevant or potentially revealing. At the same time, contextualizing quotes with meaningful participant descriptors can support interpretive richness without implying representativeness.
- Describe protocol development as an interpretive act. Explain how the interview guide, probe design, or data-gathering process emerged from theoretical commitments, ethical sensibilities, and the research team’s assumptions. Make visible how power and positionality shaped what was asked—and what was possible.
- Explain the coding process by foregrounding interpretive decision-making. Describe how meaning was constructed through memoing, dialogue, iterative reading, and theoretical engagement—without implying that coding is an objective or mechanical procedure.
- Use the discussion of analysis to be methodologically explicit. Name the analytic approach (e.g., reflexive thematic analysis, grounded theory, phenomenological analysis) and explain how the epistemological stance aligns with it. Make clear that method is inseparable from interpretive commitments.
- If a codebook is used, justify its purpose without positioning it as IRR-oriented. Clarify whether it served as an organizing scaffold, teaching tool, or communication aid—not an instrument for coder interchangeability. Its function is to support thinking, not to ensure that all coders “apply the same codes.”
- Treat themes as matters of conceptual salience, not quantification. Avoid participant counts or phrases such as “many,” “most,” or “the majority,” which imply measurement. Reflexive work attends to how and why a theme matters—not how often it appears.
- Use positionality statements only when they illuminate interpretation. Reflexivity involves openness, restraint, and ongoing interrogation of assumptions—not cataloging identity attributes. The positionality that matters is methodological, not autobiographical: how the researcher’s standpoint shaped analytic choices.
- Do not apologize for “limited generalizability.” Interpretive qualitative work produces concepts, insights, and theoretical contributions. It is not designed to generalize statistically or set up quantitative validation. Its value lies in explanatory power, not representativeness.

Taken together, these commitments illustrate how generative reflexivity operates at the level of method: by making interpretation visible, by refusing the language of measurement, and by grounding analytic choices in epistemological stance rather than biographical disclosure. Yet generative reflexivity is not only a set of procedures. It is also a deeper orientation toward inquiry—rooted in humility, interpretation, and an awareness of how easily researchers can misrecognize what they seek to understand. We turn next to this underlying orientation.

7.1 From Identity to Humble Interpretation

Generative reflexivity does not assume that proximity guarantees understanding. Instead, it begins from the possibility of misrecognition—of seeing too much, too little, or the wrong thing altogether. This stance allows for surprise, contradiction, and resonance without collapsing difference, or, for that matter, reifying distance. Reflexivity, in this view, is not a checkpoint but a continuous, embodied orientation toward the limits and affordances of interpretation.

This orientation aligns with phenomenological approaches that call for “bracketing” assumptions—not to erase identity, but to temporarily decenter it in service of participant meaning-making [62, 70]. Lived experience remains central—but so does the researcher’s responsibility to contextualize it. Scholars such as Mol [64], Hook [47], and Costanza-Chock [16, 18] exemplify this stance.

Mol [64], for example, integrates her analytic presence into observations of care practices—not as autobiographical exposition, but to surface frictions between bodily practices and institutional norms. Likewise, Hook centers her bodily experiences as a situated point of departure, foregrounding ambiguity, provisionality, and a willingness to let meaning emerge rather than be asserted. In both cases, reflexivity remains tethered to inquiry rather than subsumed by biography, modeling how understanding unfolds through situated engagement with data, theory, and practice. Similarly, Costanza-Chock [16, 18] draws on their own identity not to credential their analysis but to invite readers into the lived experience that grounds their critique and design insights. Following Hook [47], Costanza-Chock, and others, we look to scholars like Laura Forlano [34], whose line of cyborg scholarship—rooted in her lived experience with a digital diabetes monitor—demonstrates how embodied, situated positionality can generate theoretical and design insights that move beyond mere self-disclosure.

Reflexivity, however, is not inherently ethical, disruptive, or transformative. As Pillow cautions, reflexive practices often risk becoming “confessional,” “cathartic,” or a methodological “cure”—offering comfort to the researcher rather than friction or critique [66]. In contrast, her call for an “uncomfortable reflexivity” invites methodological awkwardness, resists easy resolution, and insists on dwelling with contradiction.

This commitment to situated, iterative interpretation echoes early interpretivist traditions in HCI—particularly Suchman’s work on situated action—which emphasized that meaning and intelligibility emerge through interaction, not from fixed identities or predetermined schemas [78, 79]. Generative reflexivity builds on this legacy, foregrounding humility and accountability as essential to rigorous interpretive work.

7.1.1 What does this look like in practice? Generative reflexivity is not a call for more biography or more generalizability; it is a commitment to tracing how interpretation evolves throughout the research process. In practice, this means documenting how assumptions surface, are challenged, and shift through engagement with participants and data, treating interpretation as a dynamic, iterative act.

In CHI and CSCW research, this often means allowing tensions and ambiguities to remain present long enough to guide deeper analytic work. For instance, in one author’s reproductive privacy interviews, what initially appeared as individualized risk perceptions ultimately revealed deeper relational and embodied dynamics shaped by medical histories, family relationships, and clinical encounters. Likewise, in our research with teens on algorithmic identity, early narratives of convenience and empowerment gave way, through comparative analysis, to more complex patterns of algorithmic attunement and identity rehearsal.

Generative reflexivity in these cases required resisting the urge to treat marginality as inherently revelatory or to seek premature analytic closure. Instead, we held these tensions provisionally, using them as waypoints for rethinking theory, refining interpretation, and iteratively strengthening our methodological approach.

7.2 Beyond Individuals: Toward Contextual Synthesis

Qualitative research in HCI is most powerful when it connects situated accounts to broader patterns—how people navigate AI systems, how algorithmic infrastructures shape discourse, and how design interventions ripple through cultural and institutional contexts. Such connections do more than illuminate experience; they enable theorizing, meaningful comparison, and—where appropriate—inform later operationalization. This orientation centers the attributes most relevant for interpretation and intervention and reveals how apparently contradictory accounts can index shared cultural logics or structural tensions. Reflexivity here serves synthesis, helping researchers trace connections across difference without presuming uniformity. It asks: What does this variation tell us about the contexts that shape it?

This is not a turn away from vulnerability. As a field, we must still identify and attend to those at highest risk—what Citron calls canaries in the coal mine [12]—and be permitted to extrapolate from their cases. But when every account is treated as wholly singular, we lose connective tissue that could strengthen claims and build shared cause.

There is also an analytic cost. Critical inquiry must examine not only who participants are but the contexts that shape what they can do, know, and risk. Identity should be treated not as an endpoint but as a process formed through social, structural, and cultural forces. Following Patricia Hill Collins, intersectionality is not a quota for inclusion but a tool for mapping systems of power in context [15].

This reorientation clarifies, rather than rejects, feminist and situated approaches. Where unaccountable algorithms flatten identity into inference, generative reflexivity reclaims interpretation as situated and deliberate. Even in quantitative or computational work, integrity depends on transparent reasoning, theoretical scaffolding, and accountable modeling.

Engaging synthesis also means adopting a form of generalizability appropriate to interpretive work. The value is not statistical reach but building concepts that can travel—claims and constructs that can be tested, contrasted, and refined across settings. This is done with the expectation that insights can generate concepts and hypothesis or theory for future quantitative testing. But it does not work in reverse: one should not survey populations to conduct qualitative interviews.

7.2.1 What does this look like in practice? Generative reflexivity at the level of synthesis entails an explicit search for patterns while honoring situatedness. Analytically, this involves documenting how codes consolidate across cases, tracing where provisional explanations fail and are revised, and making visible how disciplinary assumptions shape—not merely describe—the data. It shifts analysis beyond identity as a singular lens. Rather than defaulting to demographic categories, generative reflexivity surfaces the attributes and dynamics most probative for explanation—positioning subsequent empirical work to test models that are theoretically grounded rather than merely representational.

8 Conclusion: Reflexivity in Service of the Public Good

Reflexivity remains an important resource for qualitative HCI that can make the interpretive work more visible and accountable. The challenge is reconnecting it with the analytic reasoning through which qualitative research through which qualitative knowledge is produced. Doing so means moving beyond biography—identity disclosure and hyper-fragmentation or into methodological defensiveness—rejecting IRR while still quantifying codes and prevalence—it becomes performative rather than interpretive. In both cases, reflexivity risks obscuring the very forms of knowledge HCI needs most: shared understanding, pattern recognition, and actionable insight.

We have argued for a recalibration: a move away from reflexivity as confessional identity disclosure and away from performative rejections of rigor, toward a form of reflexivity that is embedded in analytic process. Generative reflexivity is not about cataloging who we are as researchers or defending any particular technique (e.g., refusing IRR), but about clarifying *how we know*—how interpretation was constructed, challenged, and revised. It does not treat marginality as inherently revelatory, nor assume that identity confers epistemic authority. Nor does it imply that qualitative work is more legitimate when it approximates quantitative forms (e.g., counts, prevalence claims, or generalizability). Instead, it foregrounds how structural and cultural conditions shape both participant experience and researcher understanding. Reflexivity, in this sense, is a counterweight to algorithmic thinking: it resists the flattening of identity-as-input and the methodological slide toward predictive modeling without explanation. Generative reflexivity affirms the value of transparent reasoning, provisional claims, and emergent patterns—knowledge that is accountable not because it is measured, but because it is interpreted.

This kind of reflexivity should be evident in the work: in how we frame questions, build theory, and speak across difference. Reflexivity is a responsibility to carry. If reflexivity is to remain a meaningful part of HCI's methodological repertoire it must serve more than the researcher; it must serve the work.

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